

REPORT

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Abstract

This report documents the project journey of a multidisciplinary design challenge conducted as part of the International Design Business Management (IDBM) Master's Programme at Aalto University. In this programme, students from diverse academic backgrounds collaborate in teams to address real-world challenges provided by partner organizations, with mentorship from course staff.

This particular challenge was developed in collaboration with Aseman Lapset ry, an organization focused on fostering trust and safety among young people through school-based programs and mediation services. The design brief, "Prototyping Generative AI in Youth Work," focuses on exploring how generative AI technologies can be integrated into youth mediation practices. The objective was to investigate how such technologies might support trust-building between adults, such as parents, teachers, and social workers, who are involved in resolving youth conflicts.

The project addressed a critical yet often overlooked aspect of school conflict: the emotional readiness of adults participating in youth mediation. While youth and the mediation itself are the focus of most interventions, this project explored how generative AI could support adults in preparing for mediation with greater clarity, reflection, and emotional awareness. Through secondary research, interviews with professionals in Seoul, and iterative design sprints, the team developed Mirra, a digital tool that uses AI to guide adults through emotional reflection and generate summaries that can aid mediators' preparation. The concept was presented at the 2025 IDBM Impact Gala and received positive feedback from stakeholders. This report outlines the full process from discovery to delivery, and reflects on future directions for integrating AI into social support systems.

1 Intro

The following section outlines the report structure, introduces the interdisciplinary team, and summarizes the project timeline.

1.1 Structure

This report follows a human-centered, design-driven approach guided by the Double Diamond framework (Design Council, n.d.), which structures the process into four iterative phases: Discover, Define, Develop, and Deliver - and that also shapes the structure of this report.

The report begins with an introduction to the project context, including background on the collaborating organization Aseman Lapset ry, an overview of the multidisciplinary student team, the project timeline. The Discover phase outlines the initial exploration of the design challenge, including stakeholder and target audience analysis. It presents insights gained through both secondary research, covering themes such as youth work, mediation, trust, and emotion, and primary research involving interviews with professionals such as mediators, teachers, leadership experts, psychology professionals, AI Startups and social workers in Finland and Korea. In the Define phase, research findings are synthesized to reframe the design challenge, with a particular focus on supporting the emotional readiness of adults prior to mediation sessions. The Develop section details the ideation process, exploration of multiple design visions, and the iterative prototyping of Mirra, the developed digital reflection tool. This phase includes user testing, refinement of the user experience, and the integration of AI to support structured emotional reflection. The Deliver phase introduces the final concept and describes its presentation pitch at the 2025 IDBM Impact Gala, along with stakeholder feedback and validation. The report concludes with a Discussion and Future section, which reflects on the project's challenges and outcomes, explores the broader implications of using AI in sensitive social contexts like youth mediation, and offers thoughts on future development and impact.

1.2 Team



Figure 1: Team (Jihea, Johanna, Jenny, Isaac, Lilo)

Our project team consists of five students (Figure 1) from Aalto University's International Design Business Management (IDBM) programme, bringing together diverse academic backgrounds that enrich the interdisciplinary nature of the project. Johanna Svea Weigel and Jihae Kim are majoring in Collaborative and Industrial Design (CoID) with IDBM as their minor. Liselotte Frederique Molin specializes in design, Isaac Jyväsjärvi focuses on business, and Jenny Leppänen brings expertise in technology through her chemical engineering background, all within the IDBM major.

The team's goal was to create a practical, user-centered tool that could be easily integrated into Aseman Lapset ry's existing work, supporting adults involved in youth mediation to engage with greater trust and emotional clarity.

While collaboration was central to the team's working style, roles were assigned to best utilize individual strengths and streamline the project workflow. Johanna took on the role of Project Manager, overseeing timelines and team coordination. Jihae and Liselotte led research and design activities, transforming insights into effective design concepts and deliverables. Isaac acted as Communication Coordinator, managing external communications and stakeholder relations. Jenny contributed broadly across the project but was particularly instrumental during user testing and prototype iteration phases. Together, the team worked iteratively and collaboratively, combining their interdisciplinary expertise to bring the project vision to life.

1.3 Timeline

The project ran from mid-November 2024 to the end of May 2025 (Figure 2), following a structured human-centered design process. After preparatory lectures in November, client briefs were introduced in January, officially launching the project. From January to late March, the team explored the problem space through secondary and primary research. This phase included a field trip to Seoul, South Korea, in late February, where the team investigated how AI is used in emotional and mental health support. Following the synthesis of findings and a redefinition of the design challenge at the end of March, the team entered the solution space in April. Three initial design visions were developed, tested, and refined through iterative prototyping, including the integration of generative AI. The project concluded in late May with the IDBM Impact Gala, where the final concept was showcased through a live pitch and exhibition booth, followed by a final presentation to Aseman Lapset ry.

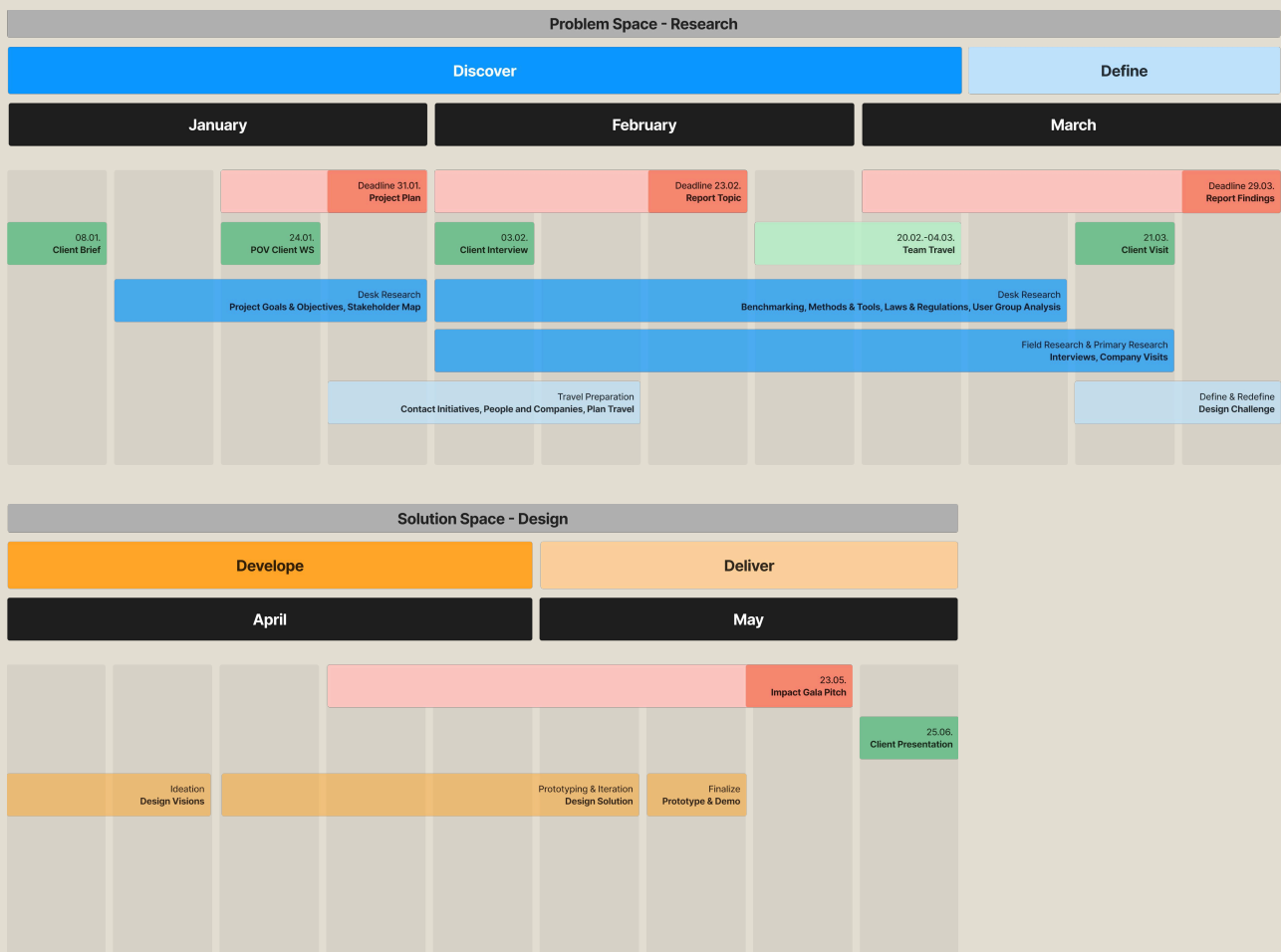


Figure 2: Timeline

2 Discover

This section outlines the initial exploration of the design challenge, including stakeholder and target audience analysis. It presents insights gained through both secondary research, covering themes such as youth work, mediation, trust, and emotion, and primary research involving interviews with professionals such as mediators, teachers, leadership experts, psychology professionals, AI Startups and social workers in Finland and Korea.

2.1 Design Problem

Our team is collaborating with Aseman Lapset, a national youth work organization founded in 1990 in Helsinki and dedicated to fostering safe and meaningful connections between adults and young people. Aseman Lapset specializes in conflict resolution through initiatives such as Street Mediation and B-Stop.

Drawing on their experience, Aseman Lapset has identified recurring systemic challenges that hinder effective mediation between adults. These include deep-seated emotions, cultural misunderstandings, long-standing disputes, and a lack of prior interaction between the conflicting parties. Families often approach mediation with mistrust, shaped by past negative experiences with institutions such as schools, police, or social services. These histories make open and honest communication difficult. Conflicts frequently arise from communication breakdowns between parents and institutions, especially schools, leading to defensive attitudes and misaligned expectations. A common issue is that participants, particularly teachers, may perceive themselves as neutral, while unknowingly contributing to the conflict. Meanwhile, parents often struggle to articulate their concerns, falling back on generalized mistrust or surface-level complaints. These dynamics erode trust and prevent meaningful dialogue, undermining the potential for successful mediation.

To address these complex challenges, this project aims to develop an AI-supported conflict resolution tool that enhances mediation between adults, particularly parents, school authorities, and social workers. These stakeholders often operate in emotionally charged, culturally sensitive situations where trust is fragile and difficult to build. The goal is not to automate mediation, but to support it by strengthening trust, empathy, and reflection. The envisioned AI tool should help social workers and mediators improve the quality and effectiveness of their efforts by facilitating emotionally grounded and culturally aware communication.

At the outset, our design challenge was framed as a straightforward question: how might we develop an AI-supported conflict resolution tool that enhances mediation between adults? However, as our research progressed and we engaged more deeply with practitioners in the field, our understanding of the problem evolved. We began to recognize the importance of the emotional dynamics that occur before formal mediation begins. Rather than viewing mediation as a single event, we came to see it as a broader journey that includes the pre--mediation phases. This shift in understanding led us to begin reframing our challenge, which we discuss in more detail in the Define section. For now, our focus remains on designing a tool that supports human connection and emotional clarity in mediation - not by replacing mediators, but by amplifying their capacity to facilitate constructive, reflective, and trust-building dialogue.

Stakeholder and Target Audience Analysis

The stakeholder ecosystem (Figure 3) surrounding this project is multifaceted, reflecting the complexity of youth conflict mediation. Aseman Lapset plays a central role as both the client and coordinating organization, while the project is connected to a wide range of primary and secondary stakeholders who each contribute to, or are impacted by, the mediation process. Designing a tool that supports this engagement requires a nuanced understanding of the behaviors, needs, and expectations of each stakeholder group.

The primary stakeholders include key adult participants in mediation, such as parents, school authorities, and social workers.

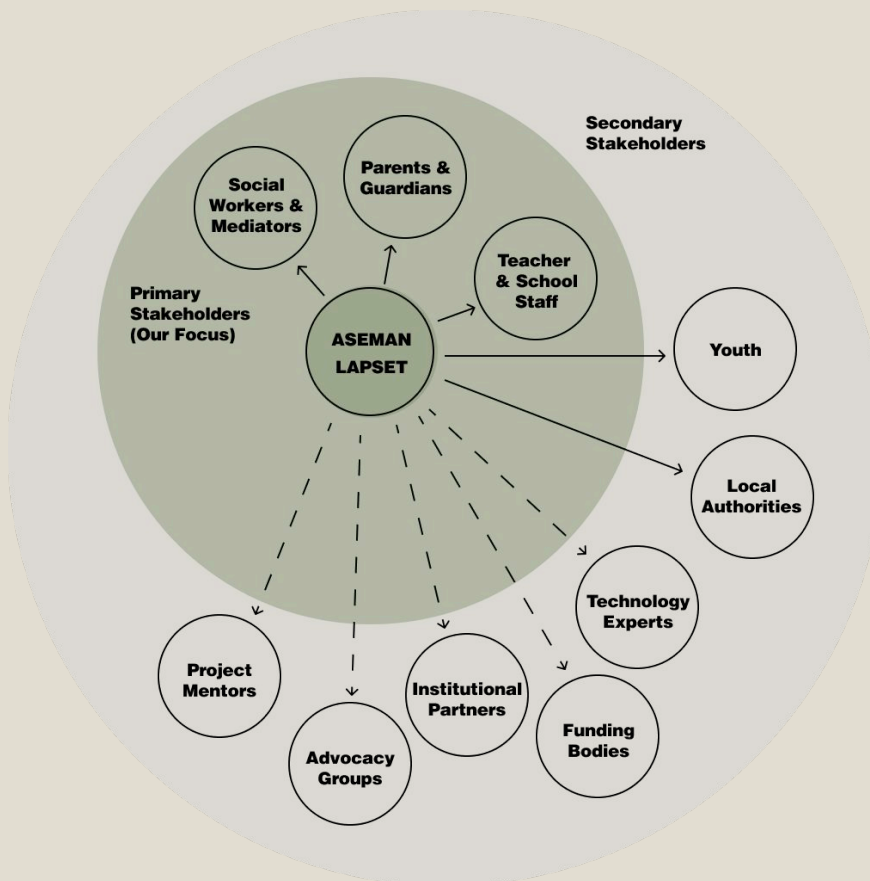


Figure 3: Stakeholder Map

Parents and guardians are often central to mediation processes, entering with complex emotional and cultural histories that influence their engagement. Many come to mediation from a place of frustration, fear, or mistrust, particularly if they have experienced judgment or exclusion from institutions like schools or social services. Differences in cultural background, parenting styles, and past negative interactions frequently create communication barriers. Parents may find it difficult to express their concerns in formal environments and can be alienated by the institutional tone or structure of mediation. To be effective, the tool must support their emotional readiness and provide space for self-reflection. They need emotionally safe, empathetic communication and clear, structured support, often requiring culturally sensitive approaches and language assistance. Their behavior tends to favor tools that offer simple guidance, accessible summaries of the conflict, and prompts that help articulate their views. Ultimately, their goal is to protect their child's well-being and to feel genuinely heard and respected throughout the mediation process.

Teachers and school staff also play a significant role in youth conflict mediation, but often feel underprepared. While they are positioned as institutional actors, they may lack the self-awareness or training required for emotionally sensitive communication. Time constraints, pressure to maintain authority, and systemic limitations can lead to defensive postures and misaligned expectations when engaging with parents. Educators require tools that are efficient and minimally disruptive to their routines, ideally supporting structured communication and de-escalation without adding administrative burden. They tend to favor solutions that streamline documentation, track mediation progress, and offer conversation cues. Their overarching goal is to resolve conflicts efficiently while sustaining trust with parents and maintaining a safe and supportive learning environment.

Social workers and mediators, particularly those from Aseman Lapset, serve as the bridge between conflicting parties. Their work is emotionally intensive and demands both adaptability and neutrality. These professionals routinely navigate high-stress situations involving diverse perspectives and systemic challenges. They rely on tools that are ethically grounded, flexible, and responsive to complex human dynamics. Rather than rigid protocols, they benefit from technologies that support their expertise, prompt reflection, aid emotional regulation, and guide dialogue without replacing human judgment. Their main objective is to foster long-term conflict resolution, rebuild trust among stakeholders, and deepen mutual understanding of the broader social context in which the conflict exists.

In addition to these primary actors, there are several indirect stakeholders whose input or support contributes to the development and success of the tool.

Children and youth, while not using the tool directly, are the ultimate beneficiaries of improved mediation practices.

Local authorities, such as social services, police, and legal advisors are occasionally involved in mediation and may influence how conflicts are handled at an institutional level.

Technology experts, including AI developers and UX designers, ensure the tool is feasible, user-friendly, and ethically aligned with best practices in digital design and data use.

Funding bodies and institutional partners, including organizations supporting Aseman Lapset and other NGOs, are invested in scalable and ethical applications of AI for social innovation and public service. Their involvement is critical for long-term sustainability and potential wider adoption.

Advocacy groups, such as multicultural organizations, provide insight into community needs and help promote the cultural relevance and acceptance of the tool.

Lastly, **project mentors** act as liaisons between the student team and Aseman Lapset. They facilitate communication, clarify expectations, and support the strategic direction of the collaboration.

2.2 Secondary Research

To design an ethically responsible and contextually relevant solution for adult conflict mediation, we grounded the early phase of our project in secondary research. As outlined in Section 2.1, our design challenge is to support adults in emotionally complex mediation scenarios. These situations often stem not merely from behavioural disagreements, but from a deep interplay of emotional, institutional, and cultural dynamics. Many participants approach mediation with prior negative experiences with institutions, creating an atmosphere of mistrust and emotional charge.

Our secondary research unpacks the systemic, emotional, and cultural dimensions of youth conflict and adult mediation. We reviewed academic theories on conflict, mediation, trust, emotional regulation and intercultural communication. We benchmarked existing digital and AI-supported mediation tools, and we studied the legal frameworks that govern their ethical application. This helped us ideate early design principles and informed our approach to primary research, which is explored in Section 2.3.

Understanding Youth Work

Youth work forms the broader institutional context of our project. According to the Finnish Youth Act (2016), youth work aims to support young people's growth, independence, and social inclusion through trust-based relationships and early intervention (Finnish Ministry of Education and Culture, 2016). It is fundamentally values-driven, focusing on safety, participation, and cultural sensitivity. Youth workers operate at the intersection of communities and institutions, facilitating dialogue and preventing conflict. These principles align with Aseman Lapset's ethos and helped shape our own design values: to promote agency, psychological safety, and inclusivity.

What Is Conflict?

Conflict can be understood as both a psychological and social phenomenon. Coser (1956) categorises conflict into two types: realistic (based on tangible needs) and non-realistic (driven by emotional or symbolic motives). Thakore (2013) and Breuer and Elson (2017) underscore how perceived threats to values or identity intensify conflict.

To visualise the hidden drivers of conflict, we adopted Hall's (1976) Iceberg Model, which distinguishes between observable behaviours and underlying emotional or cultural factors. Visible expressions like anger or silence are only the tip of the iceberg; beneath lie assumptions, fears, past trauma, and power dynamics. Recognising this complexity helped us understand that surface-level communication tools would be insufficient. Any intervention must reach the deeper layers of trust, identity, and emotion.

Conflict Mediation and Resolution

Mediation is a facilitated process through which conflicting parties seek mutual understanding and resolution. Proksch (2018) identifies five phases of mediation: preparation, framework, structuring, exploring interests, and closure. These stages require empathy, trust, and emotional readiness.

Restorative and relational approaches to conflict are particularly relevant in youth contexts. Lederach (1997) and Littlechild (2009) stress the transformative potential of mediation: not just resolving specific issues, but restoring trust and altering the relationship dynamics. This insight guided us to design not for resolution alone, but for emotional clarity, pre-dialogue reflection, and long-term relational healing.

Trust as a Design Priority

Trust was a recurring theme in our literature review. Alon and Bar-Tal (2016) highlight that trust is not a product of dialogue but its precondition. Without belief in the process or its facilitators, individuals are unlikely to participate meaningfully. Stimec and Poitras (2009) argue that overperforming neutrality can erode authenticity, diminishing trust.

This is especially pertinent to Aseman Lapset's work, where families may have experienced exclusion or discrimination in past institutional encounters. Riera Adrover and Casado de Staritzky (2019) emphasise that mutual trust enhances mediation outcomes. Therefore, trust must be intentionally designed into both the technological platform and its facilitation model. Our design emphasised transparent language, user control over data, and a psychologically safe environment.

Emotional Dynamics in Conflict

Emotions are often the engine of conflict. Bonilla et al. (2020) and Shapiro (2002) show that feelings such as shame, fear, and frustration can distort perceptions and derail communication. Gross (1998) describes emotion regulation as a two-fold process: antecedent-focused (before an emotional response arises) and response-focused (after the emotion has surfaced).

In mediation, emotional suppression can lead to explosive outcomes. Aseman Lapset emphasised how adults often suppress difficult emotions until they erupt. This validated the need for features that prompt early emotional processing. We began exploring tools that support emotion labelling, journaling, and narrative reflection. Emotional readiness became central to our user journey.

Culture and Communication

Cultural misalignment often fuels misunderstanding. Hofstede's (1980) cultural dimensions and Ting-Toomey's (1999) face-negotiation theory illustrate how norms related to authority, directness, and emotional expression vary widely. Avruch and Black (1991) stress that mediation must account for cultural identity, or risk alienating participants.

Aseman Lapset drew attention to many such misunderstandings: a teacher's calm tone may appear cold to a parent from a more expressive culture; a parent's emotional plea may be read as irrational. These cases showcase the importance of culturally responsive interaction. We focused on softening institutional language, accommodating different tones, and offering multilingual support to create more inclusive engagement.

Learning from Existing Tools

We reviewed several digital and AI-supported mediation tools: SenseMaker, Sekasin Chat, and TheMediator.AI. These served as benchmarks and boundary markers.

SenseMaker's narrative-based input inspired us to use storytelling as a mode of self-reflection (The Cynefin Centre, 2019). Sekasin Chat illustrated how anonymity and structured engagement can foster emotional disclosure and safety (Sekasin, 2025). TheMediator.AI provided insight into using AI-generated summaries that remain under user control, reinforcing agency (TheMediator.AI, n.d.).

These tools confirmed our hypothesis: technology should scaffold emotional clarity and trust, but never automate sensitive human interaction.

Legal Frameworks and Ethical Commitments

Designing with AI in sensitive contexts demands rigorous attention to ethical standards and regulation. Our review focused on both Finnish and EU legislation.

The Finnish Youth Act (2016) and Child Welfare Act (2007) emphasise inclusion, early intervention, and psychological safety (Finnish Ministry of Education and Culture, 2016; Finnish Ministry of Social Affairs and Health, 2007). The Act on the Provision of Digital Services (2019) ensures equitable access to public digital services (Ministry of Finance, 2019). At the EU level, the forthcoming AI Act classifies AI used in educational and emotional contexts as high-risk, mandating explainability and human oversight (European Parliament, 2024). The General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) guarantees that users retain full control over their data (European Data Protection Board, 2018).

These legal foundations guided our commitment to Value Sensitive Design (Friedman et al., 2013). Our tool would never act as a decision-maker, would default to data privacy, and would always enable users to edit or withhold their inputs.

This body of secondary research offered both conceptual grounding and design direction. It shifted our understanding from conflict resolution to conflict transformation, emphasised emotional readiness, and framed trust as a designable component. It also helped us critique existing technologies and shape ethical boundaries. Crucially, it prepared us for primary research.

2.3 Primary Research

Our secondary research laid the theoretical foundation for our primary research design, where we employed a qualitative research approach anchored in semi-structured interviews. This method allowed for adaptable questioning tailored to each participant's expertise, while still ensuring that key themes were consistently addressed. These themes included current professional experiences; perspectives on the challenges and needs of mediation, particularly regarding trust, cultural dynamics, and emotional factors; prior engagement with interventions and AI technologies; as well as aspirations and expectations for future developments. The interviews enabled open, reflective conversations that provided meaningful insights into the real-world experiences of practitioners and stakeholders alike.

We conducted 11 interviews across Finland and South Korea, representing a range of expertise: social workers, AI tool developers (e.g., AI Chat Sekasin, Counseling Cat AI), mediation experts from corporate and educational contexts (e.g., Korea International Mediation Center, Seoul North Education Center), professionals specializing in peace education and leadership experts (Table 1).

Participants were identified through professional networks and organizational partnerships, and all gave informed consent. Interviews lasted approximately one hour and were conducted in English or Korean, with translation support as needed. Each session involved a team of 2–5 researchers with different roles such as lead interviewer, translator, note-taker, and observer to ensure depth, accuracy, and contextual clarity.

The interview protocol focused on four main themes: the mediation process, emotional and cultural dynamics, experiences and expectations of digital and AI tools, and ethical concerns in AI-assisted mediation.

All interviews were recorded, transcribed, and when necessary translated for clarity. We applied a visual thematic analysis using affinity mapping. Each interview was assigned a unique color code in Figma to preserve source context. Through open coding, we surfaced major themes such as trust-building, emotional readiness, cultural friction, and attitudes toward AI in conflict settings. Key insights were then compared and synthesized with the conceptual frameworks identified in our secondary research.

Name	Number	Area of expertise	Purpose
AI Chat Sekasin	1	AI youth therapy tool	Understanding the usage and problems regarding AI in therapy for youth
Social worker A	2	Youth social worker	Understanding the process and pain points from the stakeholder perspective
Counseling Cat AI	3	AI youth therapy tool	Understanding the usage and problems regarding AI in therapy for youth
Seoul North Education Center	4	Parent mediation	Understanding the pain points and solutions in parent-focused mediation
Korea International Mediation Center	5	International conflict and B2B mediation	Learning about the different aspects of conflict resolution and mediation
Professor of peace education	6	Youth peace education methods	Learning about the different forms of peace education as they relate to mediation
Mediation expert	7	Corporate and youth mediation	Learning about the different aspects of mediation and pain points
Sangnag AI	8	Therapy methods in the digital age	Learning about and inspiration for digital therapy tools
Social Worker B	9	Youth social worker	Understanding the process and pain points from the stakeholder perspective
Leadership Expert	10	Leadership and mediation	Understanding mediation through the lens of leadership
Metaverse Counseling Center	11	AI and counseling, EdTech	Exploring hybrid approaches to youth therapy and metaverse-based counseling

Table 1: Domain overviews of interviewees

Key Insights

From these interviews, five key insights in the context of mediation processes and the role of AI emerged as especially significant. These insights directly informed the development of our design principles and shaped the direction of our proposed solution.

Insight 1: Mediation is a multi-step, trust-building process focused on understanding all perspectives.

Aseman Lapset begins mediation with one on one meetings to hear from students, parents, school staff, and/or other relevant stakeholders uncovering hidden stories and emotional triggers. People may initially withhold information due to shame or fear. These meetings help clarify misunderstood roles, such as victims being mislabeled as perpetrators. During joint sessions restorative dialogue to encourage empathy and shared understanding is emphasized. Participants are guided to consider others' perspectives, which softens defenses and supports agreement-building.

Insight 2: Mediation requires contextual and adaptive approaches.

Conflicts are deeply embedded within broader social and systemic contexts—such as family dynamics, school environments, and peer relationships. As such, Aseman Lapset avoids one-size-fits-all solutions, instead applying flexible, situation-specific responses.

To support this, they use the Cynefin framework (Snowden & Boone, 2007), which categorizes decision-making environments into five domains: Clear, Complicated, Complex, Chaotic, and Confused (Figure 4). Most youth mediation cases fall within the complex or chaotic domains, where cause-effect relationships are nonlinear and solutions must evolve through iteration and experimentation. Rigid approaches drawn from the “clear” domain can be ineffective or even harmful in these cases. For example, when a child expresses suicidal thoughts, mediators must first act quickly to stabilize the situation (chaotic) before transitioning into a more reflective, problem-solving process (complex).

Mediators also face systemic issues, like chronic school absenteeism or unmet emotional needs, which often go unaddressed due to oversimplified explanations. Across interviews, a wide range of frameworks were mentioned as essential, including restorative justice, motivational interviewing, psychotherapy principles, root cause analysis, and Nonviolent Communication (NVC). These support tailored, emotionally sensitive responses to evolving conflicts. Interviewees generally saw AI as having limited use in chaotic settings due to its preference for structured input and output.

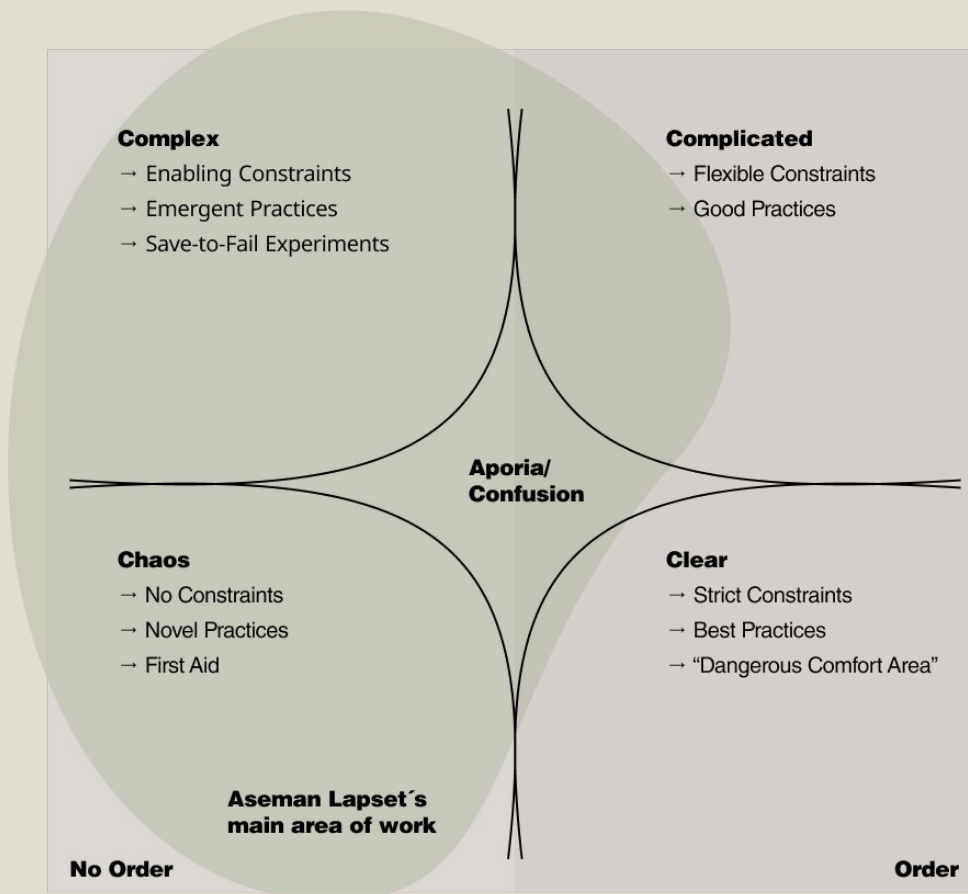


Figure 4: Cynefin framework adapted by Aseman Lapset

Insight 3: Mediation dynamics are shaped by trust, emotional awareness, and cultural sensitivity.

Trust between participants, particularly between parents and schools, is often lacking, especially when communication is infrequent or one-sided. This was particularly evident in the South Korean context, where limited parent-school interaction often led to disengagement and mistrust. Structured environments, such as facilitated joint sessions, were described as crucial for rebuilding these fragile relationships. Trust must be actively created through ground rules, confidentiality, and balanced participation. Mediators foster psychological safety by using neutral facilitation techniques, active listening, and careful consideration of physical settings like seating arrangements. Emphasizing youth voices and adhering to ethical guidelines further strengthens trust.

Emotional expression is another key factor. Although often suppressed in institutional settings, emotions play a central role in conflict resolution. Mediators help participants name and explore their emotions, triggers, and biases without escalation. Tools like perspective-shifting questions support this process and build empathy. Adults, in particular, may bring unresolved personal histories into mediation, making emotional exploration essential.

Cultural context also shapes how conflict is experienced and expressed. Mediators act as cultural interpreters, navigating language barriers, social norms, and power dynamics. In some cultures, for example, protecting family or institutional reputation may inhibit open dialogue. Gender norms may also affect who feels comfortable speaking up. Mediators must ask thoughtful questions, such as "Why?," to uncover deeper meanings and challenge cultural assumptions.

Insight 4: AI cannot replace human mediators but supports emotional processing and mediation preparation.

Interviewees consistently agreed that AI should play a supplementary role and must not interfere with the core human relationship between mediators and participants. AI was viewed as valuable in the preparatory phase, helping users reflect on their emotions, offering psychoeducation, and providing logistical support such as summaries and early risk detection.

By creating a neutral, private space for self-reflection, AI tools can help participants feel more prepared for human-led mediation. Interviewees also highlighted AI's potential to support diverse populations by recognizing emotional cues, respecting cultural nuance, and offering language translation. However, all participants emphasized that AI cannot safely handle trauma or complex emotional dynamics without human facilitation.

Insight 5: AI improves access for youth but raises trust and privacy concerns among adults.

AI was seen as especially beneficial in youth work because it offers low-threshold, always-available support. Young people were reported to be generally comfortable using AI tools, often preferring them for their anonymity and immediate accessibility. Many use AI as a first step before speaking with adults.

On the other hand, it was mentioned that adults express more skepticism towards AI, primarily due to concerns about data privacy. To build adult trust, interviewees stressed the need for robust data protection measures. These include anonymizing user data, limiting data storage, and ensuring informed consent practices in line with GDPR and the EU AI Act. Transparency and clear communication around how AI tools operate were also seen as essential for adult users to feel safe and respected.

4 Develop

After reframing the design challenge in the previous phase, we progressed into the Develop stage of the Double Diamond framework (Design Council, n.d.), shifting our focus from defining the problem to generating and shaping potential solutions.

This stage was marked by an iterative approach to ideation and prototyping. We explored a range of possible directions for the tool before converging on a coherent design vision. Through cycles of user feedback, testing, and refinement, we enhanced both the usability and emotional resonance of the experience. A key milestone was the integration of AI in our prototype, enabling the tool to guide users through structured emotional reflection in a thoughtful and supportive way.

By this point, we were already clear on our focus: supporting the emotional readiness of adults: parents, teachers, and school staff who participate in youth mediation. Our research consistently showed that while children are often the focus of mediation efforts, the emotional states and assumptions of adults play a critical role in the success or failure of those interventions.

4.1 Our Design Vision(s)

To begin generating solutions, we hosted an internal design workshop. This session built directly on the synthesis of our earlier insights and aimed to define not just what needed solving, but how we might intervene meaningfully. Rather than identifying new problems, the workshop allowed us to map the mediation journey and locate high-impact intervention points. We visualized the process as unfolding across three distinct phases:

1. Before: Emotional reflection and preparation
2. During: Facilitated mediation and communication
3. Beyond: Long-term strategy and support

Mapping the process out helped us structure our ideation. It also echoed what we had learned from Aseman Lapset's use of the Cynefin framework that most youth conflict exists in the complex or chaotic domain, where clarity is rare and different strategies are required (Snowden & Boone, 2007).

By mapping our design visions in the same non-linear way, we could ensure our concepts were actually valuable to Aseman Lapset, and the others involved in the process.

From the workshop we developed three connected design visions, each vision was based on different stakeholders and different times of the process. Although we initially considered the visions as separate options, we quickly realized their full potential was only unlocked when understood as parts of a single system.

Vision 1: Pre-Mediation AI Tool for Participants

A conversational AI interface for parents and teachers to use before a mediation session. It guides users through emotionally reflective prompts, helping them organize their thoughts and articulate their perspectives. The tool generates a structured summary which participants can review, edit, and optionally share with the mediator. This supports emotional clarity, reduces reactivity, and improves the quality of communication during mediation.

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3 Define

In the Define phase, we synthesized our research findings, which led to a reframe of our design challenge and will be discussed in the following section.

Our research into mediation practices, digital interventions, and AI integration revealed several key themes that shaped our design direction. Central to these insights is a widely shared understanding: while AI can support mediation, it cannot replace its fundamentally human nature. This reflects both the practical limitations and ethical considerations of using AI in emotionally sensitive contexts. AI can offer reflective prompts, emotional guidance, and help structure thoughts before human dialogue begins. However, the core mediation process, built on empathy, trust, and dialogue, must remain human-led. This aligns with our secondary research on human-centered AI, which stresses enhancing human capacity rather than replacing it (Friedman et al., 2013).

Another theme is AI's potential to foster self-reflection. Interviewees emphasized the emotional intensity of conflict and the value of a digital space where users can explore their emotions safely. AI can guide emotional regulation and perspective-taking, positioning it as a facilitator of insight rather than a decision-maker.

Finally, we found strong support for integrating AI with existing mediation frameworks. Interviewees and literature pointed to behavioral therapy strategies, the Cynefin framework, and models like restorative justice, motivational interviewing, and nonviolent communication as effective foundations. These frameworks ensure that AI tools are not only useful but also emotionally and ethically aligned with human needs in conflict situations.

Redefinition and Reframing of the Design Problem

Initially, our design question focused on creating an AI-supported conflict resolution tool to help enhance mediation between adults, such as parents and social workers participating in youth mediation (Figure 5). This assumed that the critical design moment was the mediation session itself.

However, our research challenged this assumption. We came to see mediation as a journey rather than an event, involving stages of before, during, and after mediation. This shift in perspective expanded our focus to include the often-neglected pre-mediation phase, where emotions run high and personal narratives remain unarticulated. Emotional readiness and self-reflection emerged as essential components in this stage, becoming central to our design thinking. This reframing prompted us to see AI not as a direct solution-provider during conflict, but rather as a supportive environment for emotional processing and cognitive preparation. The real value of AI, we discovered, lies in its ability to help adults prepare themselves for meaningful, empathetic engagement.

As a result, we redefined our design challenge to: How might we enable adults: parents, teachers, and other school staff to reflect on their emotions, roles, and expectations before participating in youth conflict mediation? (Figure 6).

This reframing opened up new directions for ideation and led to our three-part design vision, which are discussed in the next section.

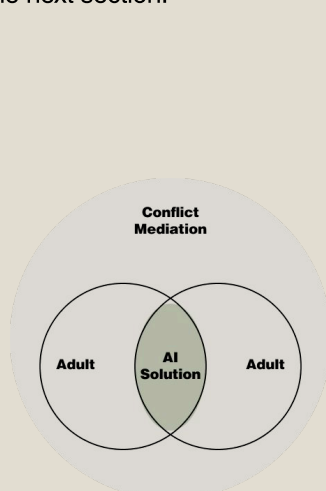


Figure 5: Initial Framing

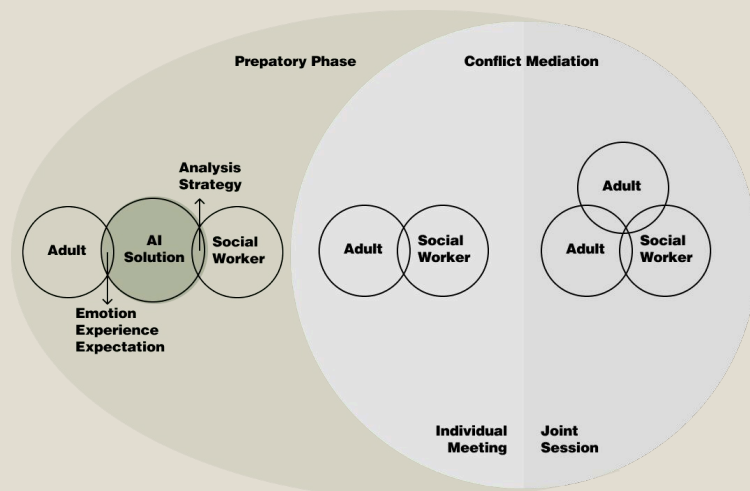


Figure 6: Reframing of our Design Challenge

Vision 2: Mediator Dashboard

This tool receives the structured input from Vision 1 and transforms it into a timeline view, highlights emotional cues, and classifies the situation using the Cynefin framework. This equips mediators with a clear and empathetic overview of the conflict before they enter the room. Mediators have a better understanding of the situation, save time and get clearer insights from everybody involved, allowing for more focused dialogue.

Vision 3: AI Strategy Assistant

Designed to support mediators and social workers post-session, this tool suggests creative, context-sensitive strategies for follow-up interventions. Based on the case's complexity and emotional tone, the assistant offers reflective prompts and pattern-based suggestions rooted in mediation practice and conflict psychology.

Final Design Vision

After presenting these concepts and gathering feedback from mentors and stakeholders, we made a decision: Vision 1 would become our foundation. Both Vision 2 and Vision 3 depended on the emotional clarity and structured input that Vision 1 provided. Without this reflective preparation from adults, the other tools would lack meaningful data to build on.

Vision 1 also responded directly to our most critical research insight: adults often enter mediation emotionally overwhelmed, misaligned in perspective, or unaware of their own assumptions. These factors disrupt trust and slow down the resolution process. By creating a “pause” before mediation, one that gently encourages emotional processing and thoughtful expression we believed we could improve the quality of the mediation itself.

The value of Vision 1 extended beyond functionality. It was also practical and low-barrier to implement, requiring minimal disruption to existing systems. It enhanced the mediator's role rather than replacing it, helping them enter the session with a clearer understanding of the landscape, rather than having to piece it together in real time.

Building a Scalable System

Although we prioritized Vision 1, we didn't discard Visions 2 and 3. Instead, we treated them as scalable extension components that could be integrated in later phases based on the success and usability of the core tool.

As part of this strategy, we prototyped elements of Vision 2, such as a simplified event timeline and Cynefin-based categorization, to test their utility for mediators. This also helped us determine what specific insights Vision 1 would need to deliver to make Vision 2 effective.

For Vision 3, we explored early ideas for an AI-assisted strategy generator. While this remained in a conceptual phase, it helped us envision the long-term potential of the tool as a full-spectrum support system for youth mediation.

This approach allowed us to focus on delivering a working, research-backed prototype within our timeline while preserving the creativity, ambition, and modular growth potential of the larger design system.

By choosing to lead with pre-mediation emotional readiness, we believe we have created a concept that not only supports mediators but reshapes the emotional foundation of mediation itself.

Key Findings & Participant Prototype Iterations

For the mediation participant side of the prototype, we implemented several changes, with the most significant outlined below:

1. Landing Page

Our initial participant prototype went straight to role selection and AI conversation, without a landing page. However, feedback from Aseman Lapset (two out of four workers) raised concerns about participants (parents and teachers) using the tool within their busy schedules, highlighting engagement issues. They were skeptical about stakeholders' willingness to input data or engage regularly. This feedback emphasized the importance of ease of use and clearly demonstrating benefits for user adoption.

To address this, we added a landing page to the final prototype that clearly communicates the value of the prototype, sets expectations for users, provides clearer guidelines about the mediation process and its benefits and explains how to use the tool (Figure 9)

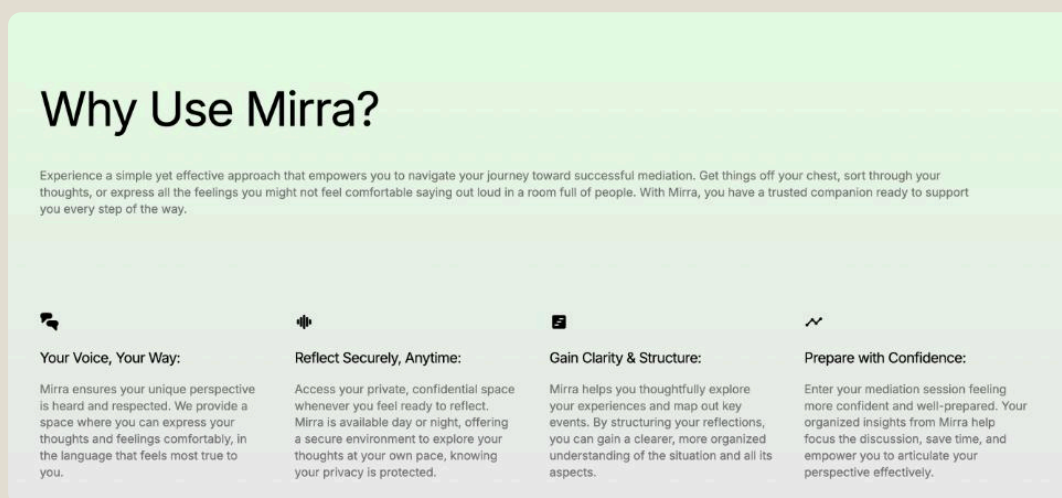


Figure 9: Landing Page - Benefits, Expectations, and Process

2. Report Generation

After using the conversational AI, a report is generated to help participants organize their emotions and thoughts about the conflict, and to share with the mediator. Initially, the report only included a summary, trigger points, and desired outcomes (Figure 10). After user testing, we gained crucial insights emphasizing the need for emotional and contextual understanding to quickly grasp the stakeholder and conflict situation. Therefore, we added the following features to the report interface (Figure 11):

- **Holistic Needs Identification:** Participants emphasized the value of recognizing broader individual needs beyond the immediate conflict. As one participant put it, “What does this person need in her life right now?”
- **External Factors:** Conflicts are often shaped by external circumstances. One interviewee pointed out, “Often conflicts also get solved when something else happens,” underscoring the importance of capturing contextual influences.
- **Detailed Emotional Analysis:** There was a clear demand for more in-depth emotional insight. Participants suggested including a richer analysis and summary of the emotions expressed, with one noting, “It could include even more detailed analysis and summary of what kind of emotions were expressed.”
- **Family Dynamics:** Understanding elements such as sibling relationships, parental status, or experiences of divorce was seen as essential for effective and holistic conflict resolution.
- **Timelines:** Adding a timeline not only for the mediator's view but also for the participant's own story helps in collecting events and understanding their personal narrative.

4.2 Prototyping UI/UX Concept

To bring our design vision to life, we began developing a prototype. The UI/UX concept was intentionally designed to be intuitive, supportive, and calming for users. Visually, the interface uses rounded shapes and soft gradients to create a gentle, non-distracting environment and to reinforce the tool's therapeutic and reflective purpose.

Following initial presentations of our design vision concepts, we identified a recurring confusion between the user interfaces for mediation participants (Vision 1; Figure 7) and mediators (Vision 2; Figure 8). While both are part of the same tool, they serve distinct user groups. To resolve this, we introduced visual consistency by applying a shared design system across both interfaces, while using differentiated gradient color schemes to clearly distinguish the two roles. This ensured coherence within the tool while allowing users to recognize which version applied to them. Initially, the prototype was named BridgePath, but this was revised in later iterations as the concept evolved.

Our first full prototype combined all three design visions into a single journey. This comprehensive version served as the basis for user testing and feedback, guiding the next stages of development.

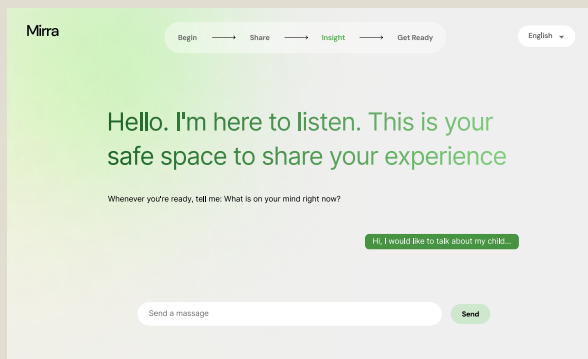


Figure 7: Mirra for participants

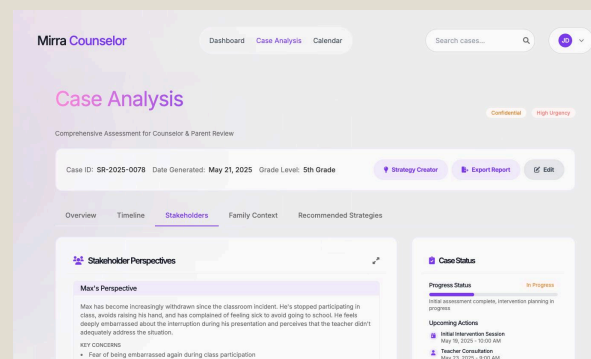


Figure 8: Mirra for mediator

4.3 User Testing & Prototype Iteration

For the user testing session, we evaluated the developed prototype, which included two distinct user interfaces. The Participant Interface featured an AI chat, report generation, and mediation preparation tools. The Mediator Interface included a dashboard, report overviews, and a mediation strategy creator.

The primary goal of this testing was to gather feedback on these early concepts, which represented our design vision. We aimed to identify usability issues, assess feature relevance, and collect insights to inform further iterations and feature selection. The testing was conducted over nine days, from April 14th to April 22nd.

A total of six participants took part: four from Aseman Lapset and two substitute teachers. Aseman Lapset participants were recruited and tested remotely via Google Meet, while the teachers were recruited through personal contacts and took part in in-person sessions. We collected data through screen and audio recordings, detailed observation notes, and post-session interviews to capture user feedback and insights.

Based on user feedback, we iterated the prototype through multiple rounds to ensure improved usability, clearer functionality, and stronger alignment with the needs of both participants and mediators.

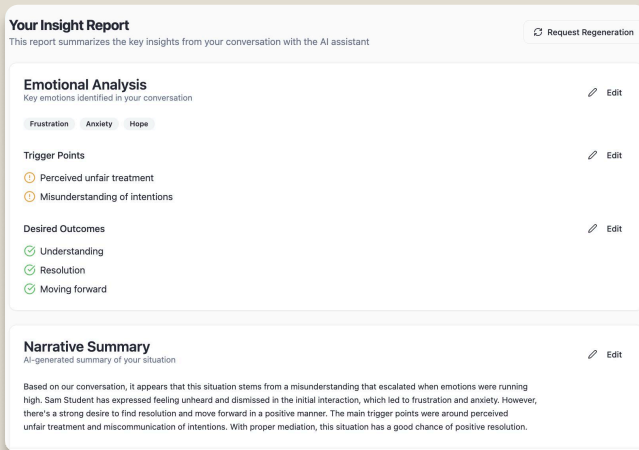


Figure 10: Report - Before

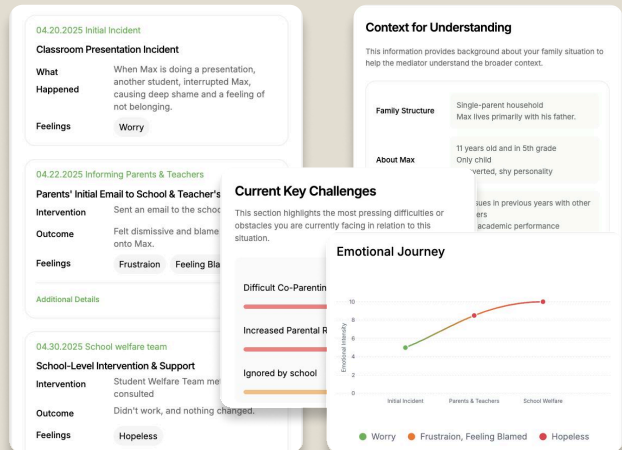


Figure 11: Report - After

3. Share the Report Section

Initially, we created a shared page where the report could be shared with multiple stakeholders, including teachers, other parents, and the police (Figure 12). However, after discussions with Aseman Lapset, it became clear that the report should only be shared with the mediator due to privacy concerns. They couldn't imagine other stakeholders viewing someone else's report. Consequently, we deleted the shared page and replaced it with a simple "Share with Mediator" button, for a simpler user experience (Figure 13).

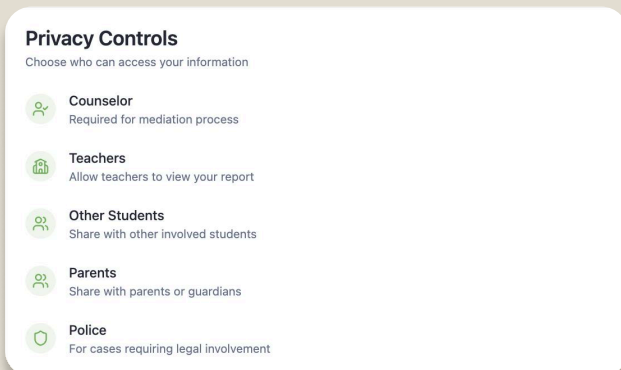


Figure 12: Share the report - Before

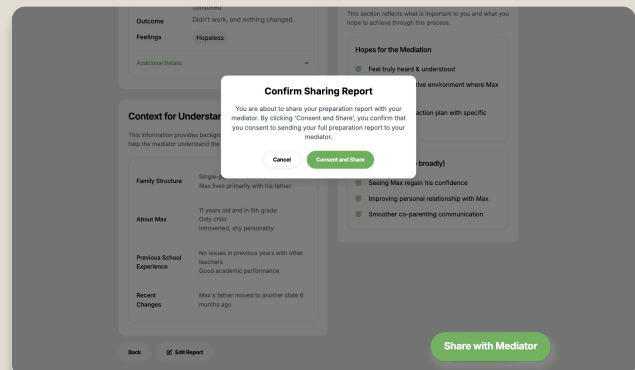


Figure 13: Share the report - After

4. Dashboard

After sharing the report with the mediator, participants can access a dashboard designed for mediation preparation. Our initial dashboard (Figure 14) showed scheduled mediation sessions, notes, and document upload options.

However, feedback from user testing indicated that mediation sessions are typically not scheduled immediately after sharing the report; Aseman Lapset usually contacts participants to schedule. So, instead of showing a scheduled session, we changed this section to "Your Steps," indicating that the report has been shared and the mediator will contact them. We also added the mediator's profile in case participants want to contact them directly or learn about them before the session (Figure 15).

Regarding adding additional files and notes, we received controversial opinions: Some feedback suggested these features were not needed, as additional files could be shared during individual discussions before the mediation session, and they aren't usually covered in the session itself. Other feedback highlighted that these features could genuinely help participants prepare for mediation, and documentation is very important. After considering this feedback, we decided to keep these functions but label them as 'additional' to avoid obligating participants. This allows users to utilize them if they wish without feeling overwhelmed.

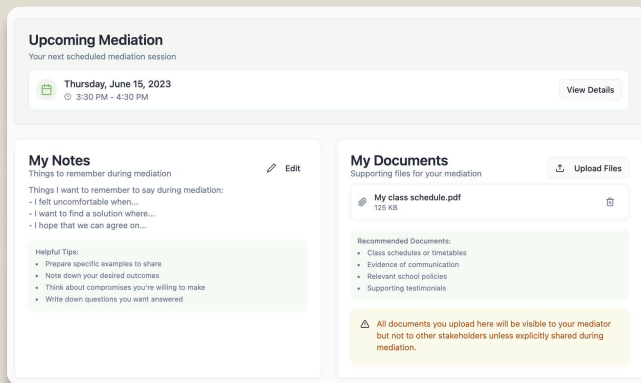


Figure 14: Dashboard - Before

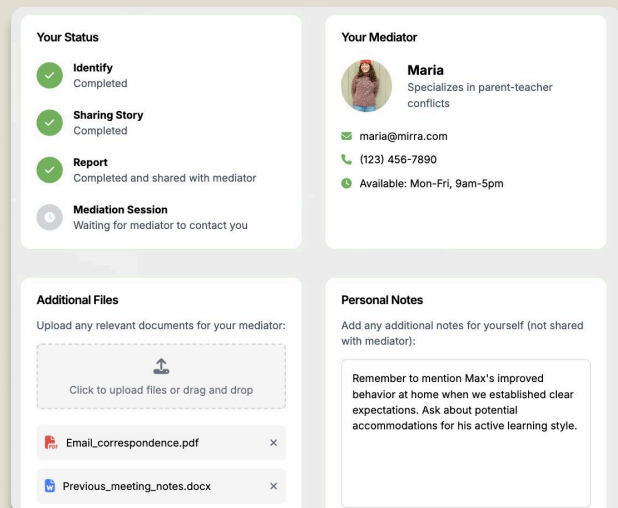


Figure 15: Dashboard - After

Key Findings & UX/UI Iteration For Mediator Prototype

For the mediator side of the prototype, we implemented several changes, with the most significant outlined below:

1. Dashboard

The initial dashboard featured a basic case overview (Figure 16), which was positively received by Aseman Lapset during user testing. However, users suggested adding filters and status indicators for solved and active cases. In response, the final version includes filters by case type and status, an overview of upcoming mediations, and additional case details such as brief descriptions and keywords, all aimed at improving clarity and usability (Figure 17).

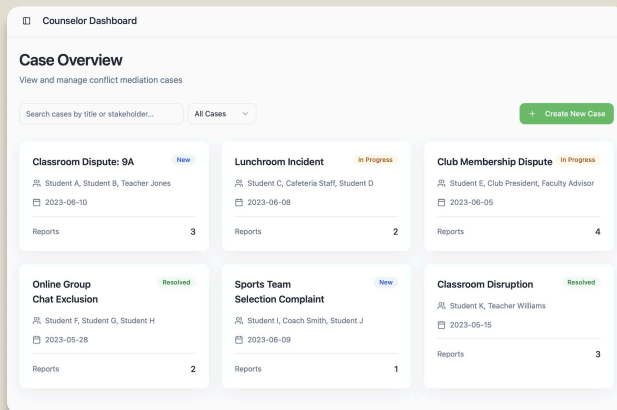


Figure 16: Mediator Dashboard - Before

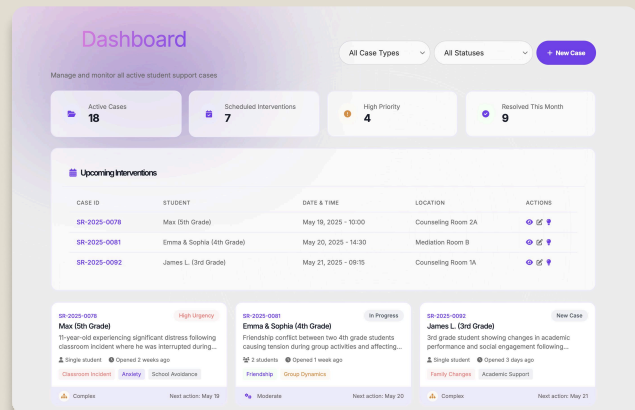


Figure 17: Mediator Dashboard - After

2. Case Analysis

From the case overview dashboard any case can be clicked to move to the specific case analysis. Before user testing the case analysis window was rather simple with a timeline of events, Cynefin framework analysis of current conflict situations and a strategy creator - all of this coming from the generated reports based on all of the case participants' conversations in the participant prototype (Figure 18).

User testing provided valuable insights into what Aseman Lapset needs to quickly grasp the full picture of a conflict. This includes understanding the broader context and the emotional states of stakeholders. To address these needs, we added five dedicated tabs to the Case Analysis page: **Overview, Timeline, Stakeholders, Family Context, and Recommended Strategies** (Figure 19).

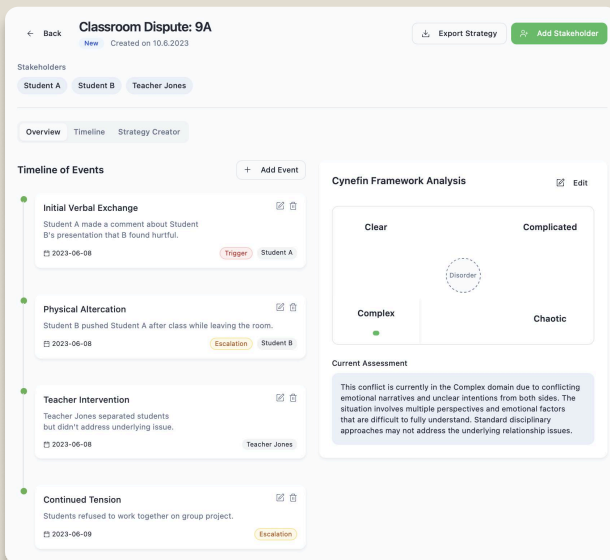


Figure 18: Case Analysis - Before

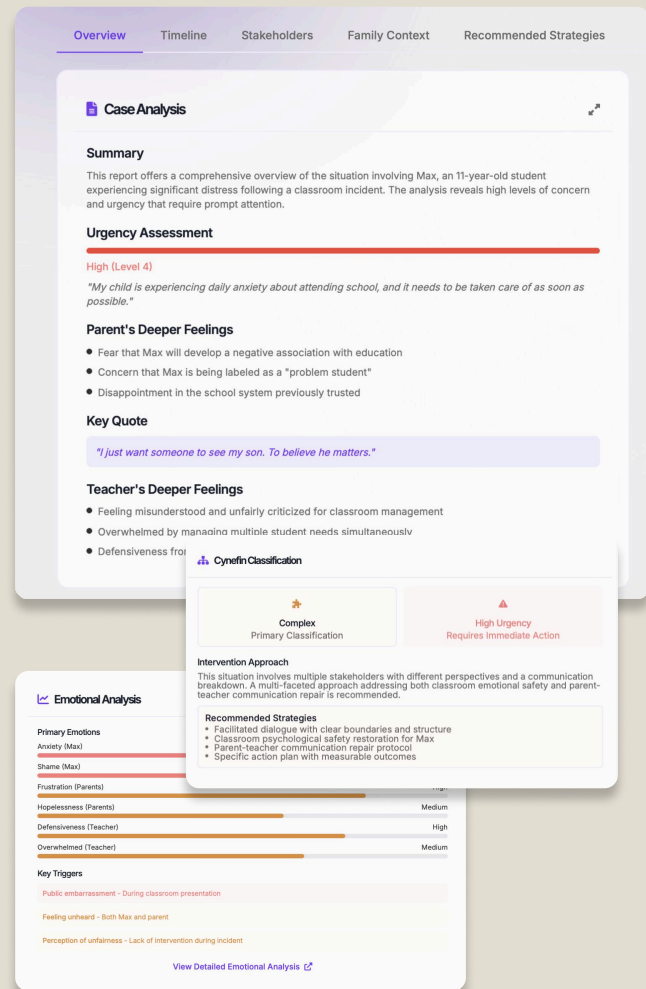


Figure 19: Case Analysis - After - Overview tab

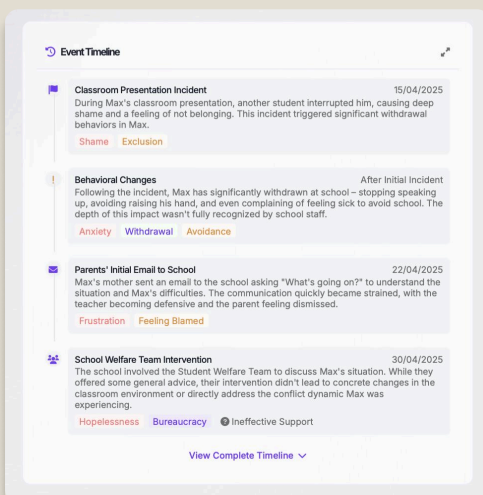


Figure 20: Timeline - After

Overview tab:

- **Case Analysis:** Includes a brief case summary, urgency level, emotional depth of stakeholders, and a key quote or goal (e.g., from a parent: "I just want someone to see my son. To believe that he matters.")
- **Emotional Analysis:** Reflects emotions verbally expressed or detected through participants' AI conversations, along with identified emotional triggers.
- **Cynefin Classification:** Integrates the original Cynefin framework from the initial prototype, showing the current classification, AI suggested strategies, and a mediator note section.

Timeline tab:

- A clearer, reorganized layout of key events, offering a structured chronological view of the case development (Figure 20).

Stakeholders tab:

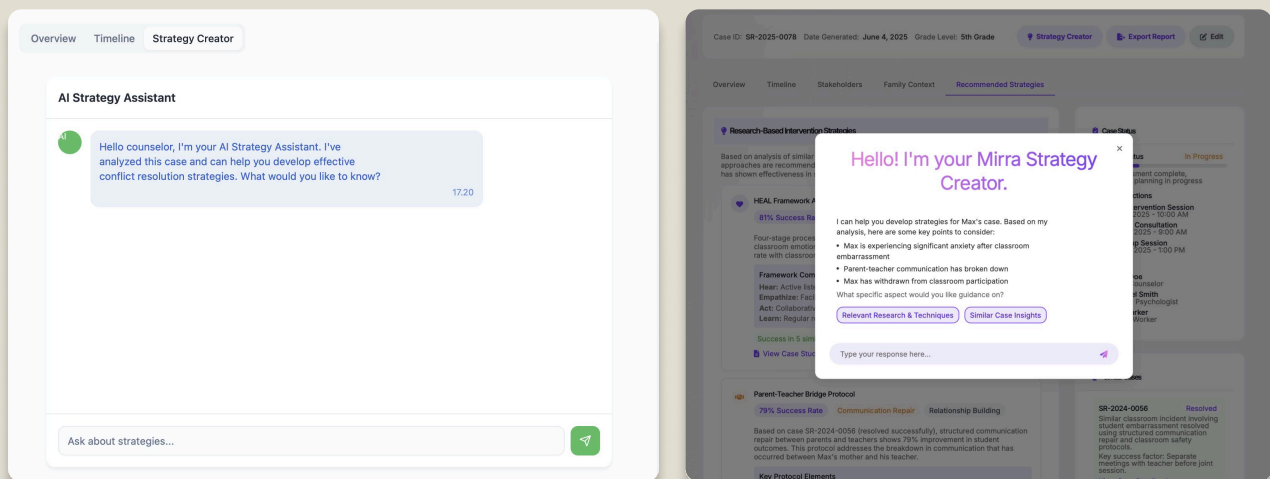
→ Individual Perspectives: Summarizes emotional responses, key concerns, and unspoken needs of each involved party. This helps mediators recognize conflicting perceptions and emotional gaps that may hinder resolution.

Family Context tab:

- Family Dynamics: Displays the structure and any recent changes in family circumstances affecting the conflict.
- Current Key Challenges: Outlines ongoing issues such as co-parenting difficulties or communication breakdowns with the school.
- Parental Hopes: Captures what parents hope for in the mediation and more broadly in life (e.g., “feel truly heard” or “see Max regain confidence”).
- Keyword Analysis: Shows commonly repeated terms in parent communications, helping mediators spot recurring patterns or themes.
- Recommended Strategies tab: → Research-Based Intervention Strategies: Offers evidence-backed strategies drawn from similar cases and relevant research.
- Restorative Opportunities: Suggests actionable next steps for building understanding, setting shared goals, and improving communication. These additions were suggested both during user testing and in feedback from Aseman Lapset.

From all of these five tabs in the **Case Analysis page**, there are features that can be accessed from any of them, which are:

- **Case status:** Showing progress status, upcoming actions, and the professional team working on the case.
- **Similar cases and related resources:** Showing similar cases (resolved or in progress) and the key success factors in those, and suggesting resources that may be helpful.
- **Strategy Creator:** An AI strategy creator that can be used as a help to ideate and develop strategies for this specific case (Figure 21 & 22).

**3. Calendar**

Before user testing, the prototype did not display upcoming scheduled or unscheduled mediations, nor did it have a calendar. From one of the user testings we received an idea to show which cases have scheduled or unscheduled meetings. This led us to get an idea to add a calendar page for the final prototype. Consequently, for the calendar page we added: a monthly view, today's schedule and a list of upcoming mediations (Figure 23). Additionally, the calendar can be filtered to only show specific types of events and own events can be added.

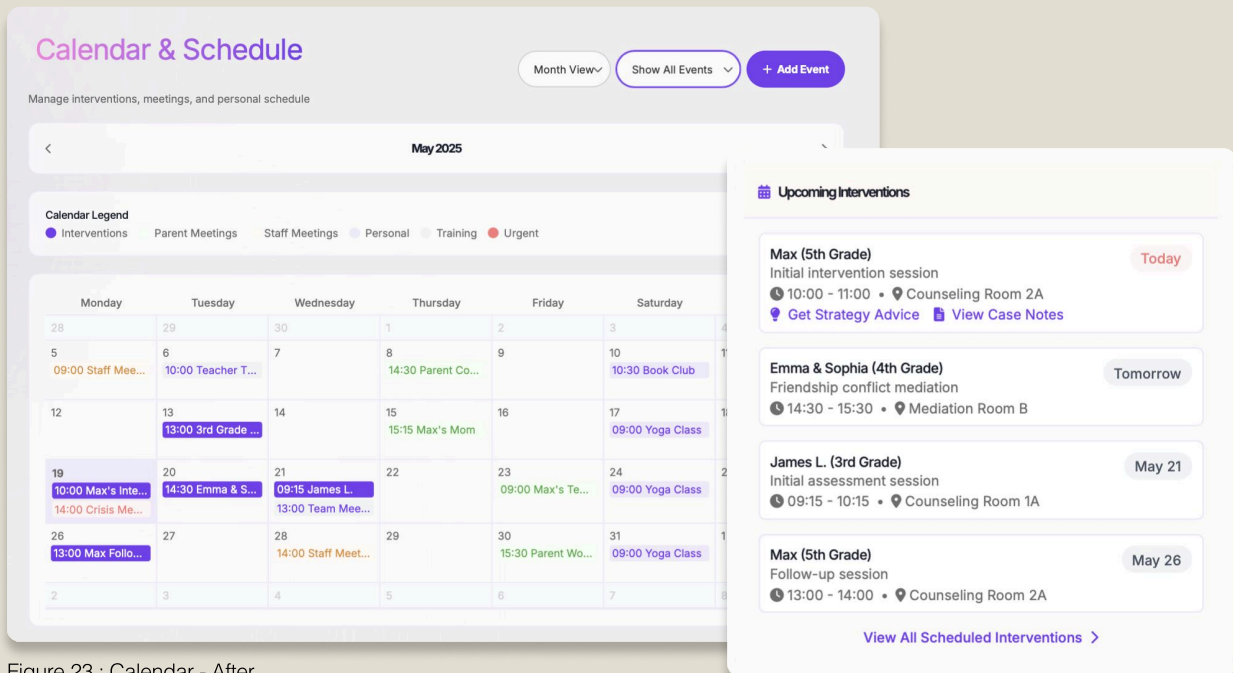


Figure 23 : Calendar - After

4.4 AI Assistant Development

In addition to the interactive prototype, we developed an AI assistant as a working demo to showcase the concept in action. The assistant is designed to guide adults through emotionally reflective conversations prior to mediation. Its purpose is to help users articulate their experiences, emotions, and needs, laying the groundwork for more constructive dialogue during formal mediation. The development of the AI assistant focused on making the concept not just visible but tangible as users could interact with a functioning chatbot within the prototype environment.

We began by creating an early version of the AI assistant using a custom wrapper application that connected to a hosted AI model via API. As development progressed, we transitioned to building the AI assistant directly within the OpenAI Assistant Platform. We used a pretrained foundation model and customize it through system instructions. System instruction comprehensive, in-context prompt that defines the AI's role and behavior to reflect the tool's emotional and ethical goals.

The AI is designed to support deep emotional reflection by drawing on proven psychological frameworks. The system instruction is carefully crafted to embed core values and conversational strategies, including:

- **Nonviolent Communication (NVC):** Helps interpret emotional expressions and uncover unmet needs to foster empathy.
- **Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (CBT):** Supports awareness of how thoughts, emotions, and behaviors interact.
- **Restorative Justice:** Encourages reflection on harm, responsibility, and paths toward repair.
- **Motivational Interviewing:** Promotes user engagement through affirming and reflective questioning.
- **Circle of Conflict Model (Christopher Moore):** Guides users in identifying the underlying causes of conflict beyond surface-level issues.

These methods are not used as therapeutic tools, but as frameworks to shape the AI's tone, prompts, and interaction style. The assistant is intentionally positioned as a supportive listener never as a decision

Iterative Testing and Refinement

To evaluate and improve the assistant, we created a fictional conflict scenario involving a school-parent disagreement. We broke this scenario into several narrative fragments and used them to test how the AI assistant responded.

Each iteration involved: Feeding the AI assistant user inputs from the conflict story; analyzing its responses for tone, clarity, empathy, and helpfulness; adjusting the system instruction based on repeated issues; and retesting the same inputs to observe improvements in the assistant's behaviour.

Throughout this process, we encountered several issues, which were for example: repetitive phrasing (e.g., always starting with “Thank you for sharing”), overwhelming responses with too many follow-up questions, formulaic language at the beginning of every message and narrow focus on users' feelings without prompting for context or background.

After multiple rounds of refinement, we developed a final version of the system instruction that created more natural, adaptive, and emotionally intelligent outputs. It balanced emotional validation with structured prompts, provided variation in tone, and respected user agency. We also tested the assistant across different GPT models and ultimately chose GPT-4.5 for its higher-quality output, particularly in multilingual contexts. We ran tests in English, Finnish, Dutch, Korean, and German, and the assistant performed consistently well across all languages, which is an essential feature for a culturally sensitive mediation support tool.

5 Deliver

The Deliver phase marks the final realization of our concept and its public presentation at the 2025 IDBM Impact Gala, along with receiving valuable stakeholder feedback and validation. Throughout this phase, our focus was on refining and communicating the design solution in its most impactful and realistic form.

5.1 Final Concept: Mirra

By the end of the Develop phase, we had two complementary components: a UI/UX prototype (culminating in a dual-interface tool featuring a participant-facing experience guiding users through emotionally intelligent reflection, and a mediator dashboard offering synthesized case insights) and a working AI assistant that engages in emotionally intelligent, structured conversations. Together, these form Mirra, a name chosen as a play on “mirror” to signify self-reflection and deeper emotional awareness. It also subtly evokes empathy, presence, and care, which are qualities our research emphasized as essential in emotionally safe mediation contexts.

Mirra fills a critical gap in conflict resolution by supporting the emotional and cognitive preparation of participants before mediation. Designed primarily for parents and teachers, it prompts users to narrate their experiences, identify emotional triggers, and clarify their goals for the session. Based on these reflections, Mirra generates a structured, editable summary that users can choose to share with the mediator. By combining AI technology with trusted mediation frameworks, it also provides mediators with synthesized, actionable insights to better understand the case in advance.

How it works: A Short User Scenario

A parent, invited to participate in school mediation, receives a link to Mirra in advance. After landing on a calming and clearly explained welcome page, they begin a guided conversation with the AI assistant. Trained in psychological reflection frameworks, the assistant gently helps users process their emotions, articulate experiences, and clarify personal goals for the mediation.

After the session, a personalized report is generated. It summarizes the parent’s emotional state, key events, triggers, and hopes for the mediation. The user can review and edit this report and decide whether to share it with the mediator. The parent can also access a dedicated dashboard designed to support mediation preparation.

On the other side, the mediator receives the report through their own interface. Reports from all participants involved in the conflict feed into a dynamic dashboard, which presents the case across five structured tabs: Overview, Timeline, Stakeholders, Family Context, and Recommended Strategies. Mediators receive an AI-assisted, editable analysis of the situation, grounded in frameworks like Cynefin, and supported by practical tools such as the Strategy Creator. All content is generated by AI but remains editable for human refinement.

5.2 Final Deliverables

Prototypes and Demo

Our created prototypes and working AI assistant demo can be accessed via the following links:

→ Participant Interface and Demo: [Link](https://aseman-lapset-prototype.onrender.com/) - <https://aseman-lapset-prototype.onrender.com/>

→ Mediator Interface: HTML File (download and open in browser to view) - [Link](https://drive.google.com/file/d/1tHZza_2h9SMe76CTWbDenPaglHNNktAd/view?usp=sharing) - https://drive.google.com/file/d/1tHZza_2h9SMe76CTWbDenPaglHNNktAd/view?usp=sharing

Card Booklet with Data Privacy Information and Cost Calculations

We also created a Card-Booklet outlining key delivery considerations, including data privacy and cost estimates.

For data privacy, it is explained that Mirra should use local data storage, and clear consent protocols aligned with GDPR and the EU AI Act. The highest privacy level can be achieved by hosting a private LLM instance on a secure server or cloud provider, such as Azure for OpenAI. This ensures full control over data processing and prevents external transmission. With open-source models like Google's Gemma3, the tool can also be hosted entirely locally.

For cost, we estimated annual expenses based on token usage (e.g., GPT-4o), usage frequency, and infrastructure needs. Cost calculation graphs from the card booklet are shown below (Figure 24):

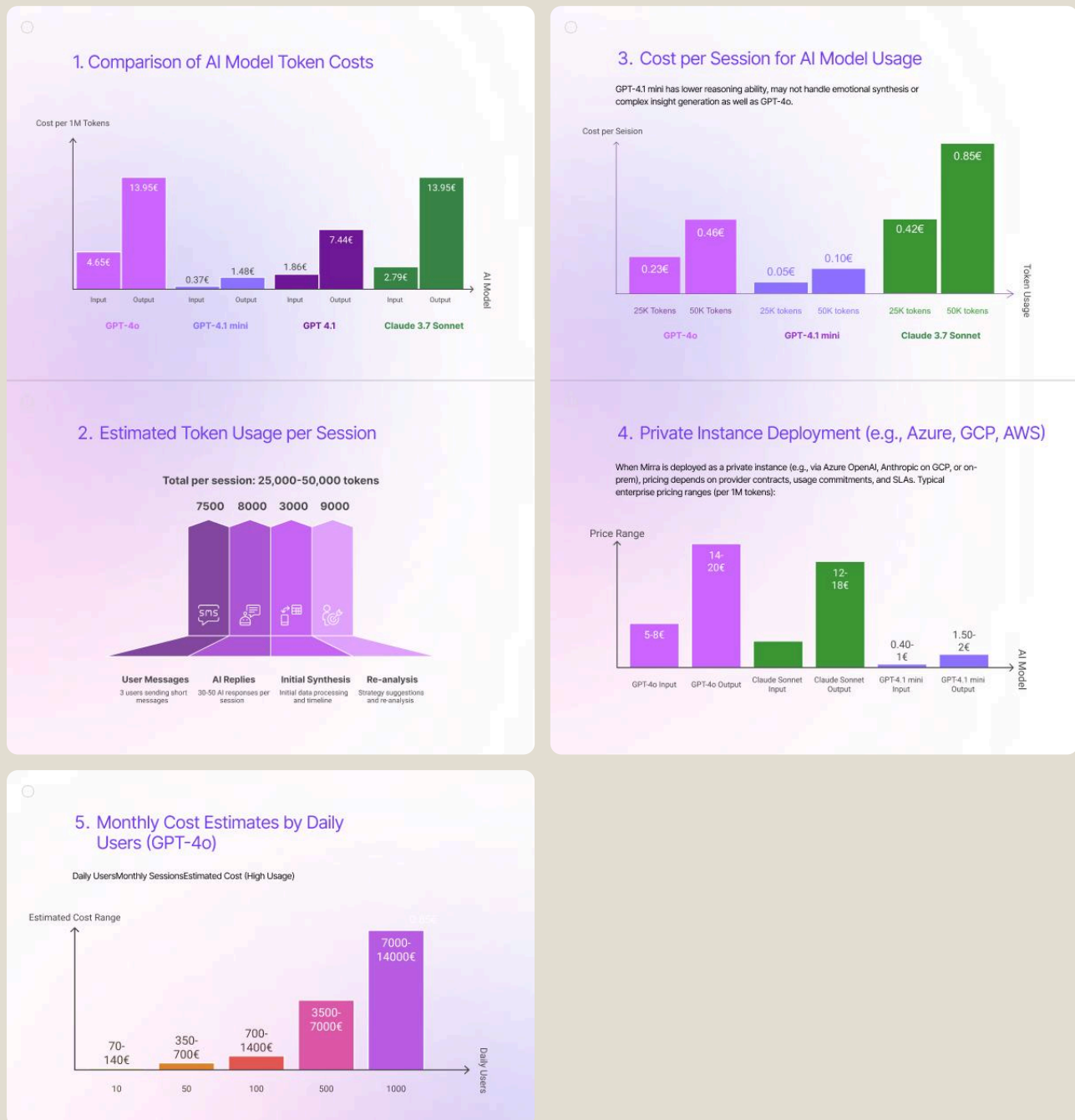


Figure 24 : Cost Calculations from Card Booklet

Pitching Mirra at the IDBM Impact Gala

We chose to introduce Mirra not through a list of features, but through story. Inspired by the Green Elephant storytelling method, our pitch at the 2025 IDBM Impact Gala centered around a fictional but research-based character: Max, a quiet student caught in a school conflict. His story, told from four perspectives (Max, his teacher, his parent, and the mediator), revealed how misunderstandings and emotional silence shape the conflict.

Rather than pitching Mirra as a “solution,” we positioned it as a turning point when adults pause, reflect, and listen better. This narrative allowed the audience to emotionally experience what the tool enables: a deeper, more human dialogue before the formal conversation even begins.

After presenting Mirra at the Gala and during our final stakeholder meeting with Aseman Lapset, the response was clear: the concept was understood and welcomed. A few employees of Aseman Lapset expressed interest in exploring how the participant-facing prototype could be piloted in real school cases. One critique offered was the desire for even deeper AI training in the prototype phase. On the positive side, Aseman Lapset especially appreciated the non-intrusive role of AI, the modularity of the tool for scaling, and its emotional sensitivity and realistic integration into existing daily workflows.

6 Discussion

As the project comes to a close, we wanted to reflect not only on what we built, but also on the emotional, ethical, and systemic questions that shaped the project for us. At its core, the project explored how design might create space for reflection in moments of conflict, and how generative AI could support and not replace human judgment by fostering emotional readiness in complex, emotionally charged situations.

6.1 Challenges and Opportunities

One of the core challenges we encountered was finding the right tone. Early in the process, we recognized that the adults involved in school conflict parents, teachers, and even mediators often carry emotional weight into the conversation. These emotions are rarely voiced: frustration, fear of blame, institutional fatigue, or quiet guilt. Our task was not to simplify those emotions but to hold space for them in a way that felt structured, supportive, and respectful. We learned that emotional design is not about softness or aesthetics alone, it's about creating systems that honour the complexity of human experience without overwhelming the user.

Another ongoing tension was navigating the cultural anxiety around AI. Even in the early phases of the project, we faced scepticism and backlash. Questions around safety, data privacy, and the fear of AI making decisions on behalf of users were ever-present. These concerns shaped our design approach from beginning to end. We focused on ensuring the system was secure, transparent, and non-prescriptive, with the AI acting more like a guide than a judge. This meant designing prompts that encouraged honest expression without exposing users to vulnerability. The tool could not diagnose or conclude; it needed to remain neutral and facilitative. Striking this balance between meaningful guidance and careful non-interference became one of our most important design lessons.

We also faced questions of trust. In emotionally sensitive contexts, AI still carries a significant stigma especially when issues of privacy and institutional power come into play. We responded with an approach rooted in transparency, optionality, and user control. At every step, the user retains ownership of their responses. The tool does not judge, correct, or categorize. It simply offers a space for reflection, which the adult can choose to share with a mediator to support a more grounded, empathetic session.

6.2 Future

While the tool remains a prototype, the feedback we received suggests that its value is both tangible and timely. At the IDBM Impact Gala, our concept created some interesting conversations not just with youth workers and educators, but also with professionals from other areas. Many reflected on their own experiences of entering emotionally charged situations without any time to prepare and expressed a desire for something like Mirra in their own fields. One visitor imagined it adapted for restorative justice between adults.

These moments showed us something that we have thought about throughout the project. Mirra is not just a tool for youth mediation. It offers a framework for emotional preparation that can scale across domains. Its simplicity is its strength. It doesn't promise solutions it offers a pause. A moment of clarity, of self-awareness, before entering into conversation. That small gesture can shift the dynamics of an encounter. In any field where emotional labour is expected but rarely acknowledged, Mirra's approach could prove valuable.

Looking forward, several next steps could help Aseman Lapset or a partner organization take this work further. Funding will be essential for technical development and piloting. Opportunities could include grants from STEA, Sitra, or Business Finland, particularly under themes of youth welfare, mental health, and ethical AI. Partnering with a technical team whether academic or industry-based would allow us to strengthen the backend, ensure GDPR compliance, and protect user autonomy.

Piloting the tool within Aseman Lapset's mediation network would allow for real-world testing, refining the interface, language, and emotional tone based on direct feedback. From there, the tool could be extended into teacher training sessions, and mediation workshops, or deployed as a lightweight app or web service. Given its modular design, the broader vision could still unfold: a dashboard for mediators, a post-session strategy assistant, or even an ecosystem of support tools built around the same core principles.

6.3 Reflection

Perhaps the most powerful future direction is not technological, but cultural. Mirra represents a shift in how we view emotional preparation within institutional life. It challenges the expectation that people will simply pull themselves together before a difficult conversation, and instead asks: what if we gave people the time and tools to understand what they're carrying into the room? This reflects a broader rethinking of AI's role not as a replacement for human insight, but as a support mechanism that creates time and space for what often goes unseen. As McKinsey & Company (2023) have noted, the future of work will depend not only on automation itself but on how we solve the human transitions around it, including time, trust, and emotional readiness.

We're proud that our work extended beyond the original brief and touched on broader societal themes: emotional readiness, trust in technology, and the value of structured care. Even small moments of reflection offered at the right time can reshape how people relate to one another. If Mirra can help even one adult pause and step into a difficult moment with more clarity and care, then it has already done meaningful work.

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Figure 24 : Cost Calculations from Card Booklet (screenshot from our card booklet design)

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Technology Statement

During the preparation of this work we used Chat GPT and Grammarly in order to restructure text, organise arguments and improve grammar. This was done in separate pieces of the work. After using these tools, we reviewed and edited the content as needed and take full responsibility for the content.